Better example:

“We learned from your VP of Eng that if your engineering team had an extra five hours per week to focus on [new product], you’d be able to launch one month early. Your VP of Product estimates the revenue impact of the early launch to be $2 million.”

To save our deal, we had to go back to the drawing board on how ROI was calculated. Fortunately, the Chief Product Officer was willing to engage, we found mutual benefit, and won the deal.

For your deals, take your business case from, “we’ll save your team time” to “you’ll accomplish x and generate $$$ with the time saved” and watch your win rate increase.

PITFALL #6:

Not accounting for Risk of Change

Sellers assume they have a deal as long as their proposed After State is better than the buyer's Current State and are surprised when they lose the deal to "no decision."

Losing to "no decision" does not mean that the buyer didn't see value in the proposed solution. Instead, they weren't convinced that their Current State needed to be abandoned. No decision means your buyer is content to keep their status quo.

Sellers forget that getting to a new After State requires change. Change = risk, and people are risk-averse.

To win, the proposed After State has to be better than the Current State + Risk of Change. As you are finalizing your business case with your buyer, make sure you aren't only quantifying the value of the proposed solution. You also need to mitigate the Risk of Change.

There are a few ways to reduce the Risk of Change:

- Well-defined implementation
- Successful proof-of-concepts
- Early introduction to service partners

However, you'll never eliminate the risk. The only way to have no risk, is to make no change, which means keeping the status quo.

So after reducing the Risk of Change, make sure your buyer understands the Risk of the Status Quo. The Risk of Status Quo should be a combination of negative consequences your buyer is aware of + negative consequences you teach them.

Identifying and teaching negative consequences is an essential skill worthy of its own book.

Fortunately, that book has been written: The Challenger Sale by Matt Dixon. If you haven't read it yet, I strongly recommend doing so.

For the mathematically inclined, here's how I'd represent this Framework:

You lose when the After State < Current State + Risk of Change

You win when After State > Current State + Risk of Change

You tilt the scales in your favor when you add Risk of Status Quo + After State > Current State + Risk of Change

PITFALL #7:

Negotiating price prior to finalizing scope

I was absolutely destroyed in my first real “negotiation.”

I was working on a customer upgrade that included more usage, more users, and more features. The original proposal was a $120,000 upgrade.

I knew there would be negotiation (the customer was notorious for beating us up on price). I wanted $100,000 from the deal.

We went back and forth a few times, and the buyer got me down to my “floor” of a $100,000 increase. Pleased with the result, I sent over the contract for signature.

Then, I got punched in the gut via email:

“Thanks for working with us on price, Kyle. Talked to the team, and we only need half as many users as we thought, 30% lower usage, and we don’t need [advanced features 1 and 2].

Can you remove those, adjust the price accordingly, and resend the contract?”

I was stuck. I couldn’t go back and say, “Ok yeah we took all of that out but the price stays the same.”

The deal ended up around $70,000 of new business - significantly lower than my original “floor” that I had negotiated towards.

My critical mistake was negotiating price before we had confirmed and finalized scope.

Like me, sellers often have a predetermined “floor” for their more significant deals. This number is often tied to quota attainment, promotion qualification, or a goal commission amount.

A savvy buyer will try and get a seller down to that floor as quickly as possible. They keep all potential features, options, and volume on the table and negotiate price off of that “optimal package.” The seller is happy to negotiate because:

1. The buyer seems to want a “premium,” higher-cost option
2. They are still above their floor

After negotiating the price down on that package, which is often at or near the predetermined floor for the seller, the buyer will remove features or reduce volume.

To avoid this pitfall, refuse to negotiate the price until the scope is finalized. When the buyer asks for movement on price, the response should be:

“We are excited to work with you and will certainly ensure we are competitive on price. To prevent unnecessary back and forth, let’s finalize exactly what you need us to provide, and then we can iron out the investment details.”

Once you have a firm commitment on scope, you can safely begin pricing negotiations without the risk of scope (and price) dropping unexpectedly.

PITFALL #8:

Proactive discounting

SAAS pricing is constantly changing and is rarely perfect. We've all had deals where we generate the quote, look at the price, and immediately recognize flaws in the model. Most reps will refuse to put a price that they know is too high in front of their customer and will present a proposal and say, "I've included an xx% discount because of *fake reasons* 1,2, and 3."

In addition to the problem of admitting your solution isn't worth the price, we run into an additional complication: they don't believe they are getting a discount.

I remember negotiating my first seven-figure contract. We made the mistake of presenting a proposal to the business with a 30% discount off the list price. Then, procurement got involved, and they told us that the executive team would not greenlight a signature until they knew they had a good deal.

I explained that we had already baked in a 30% discount and asked procurement to communicate that discount to their executive team. He said, "Kyle, for all I know, you are making that price up. You can say 'list price' is anything, and I have no way to verify if that's true. For my CFO, a 'good deal' is measured from discounts off the final proposal provided to our business."

In that scenario, we had to discount roughly 10% off of the final proposal cost to get the deal done. The lesson I learned is that we don't get credit for proactive discounting:

If the list price is $100,000, but you first show the customer $80,000 and then "sharpen your pencil" down to $60,000, your customer will give you credit for the $20,000 discount they saw, not the $40,000 discount you tell them you are offering.

PITFALL #9:

Conclusion

Even the best-run deals can stall if the seller misses critical details at the end of the deal cycle. Sellers can lose thousands of commission dollars a year by making simple negotiation mistakes.

Applying the principles in this section will help you increase your control of late-stage opportunities, increasing deal velocity, win rate, and deal size.

SALES INTROVERTS

Career Evaluation

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Introduction

Your environment is a key driver for your success. The team you are on, the role you are in, and the company you sell for will have a major impact on your growth and income.

This final section will help you navigate career decisions to maximize development, progression, and earnings.

Finding a Great Company

I've been in sales leadership long enough to watch people make both terrible and fantastic career decisions.

With few exceptions, the great decisions were made with a long-term view, while the bad decisions were short-sighted.

The challenge is it can be difficult to think long-term in our stressful and chaotic profession. One way to think long-term is to apply a framework towards how you think about your current (and potential future) roles.

This section is my framework for career decisions. I used this exact formula when I chose my next role after over eight years at Qualtrics, and selecting MongoDB ended up being one of the best decisions of my career.

While I will share my current weightings for each category, please consider how yours may be different. We are all in different times/seasons of our careers and priorities may differ. Where applicable, I will call out categories that will change weights as my career progresses to help you see how they may vary for you now.

My Big Three - each weighted at 20%

Development/Learning

I've always prioritized learning. The more I learn, the more I can teach. The more I can teach, the greater impact I can make.

Making a significant impact is the domino that makes all my other priorities fall into place.

Company long-term outlook

Especially in a down economy, I want to sell a "must-have" product for a financially stable company. I know many people who accepted roles at exciting startups for obscene amounts of money before losing their jobs shortly after the markets plummeted.

Later in my career, I may be less risk averse, and the weighting for this category may decrease. Please note: financially stable doesn't mean big company. There are plenty of small companies that are financially stable, and plenty of big companies that are bleeding cash.

Success rate of teams

I want to do well because the people I work with are doing well.

Being paid well in a winning environment is better than making more in a losing environment.

I can't imagine any career stage where this wouldn't be a priority.

Winning and losing are both contagious.

Next three (weighted at 10%)

Compensation

I have short-term, mid-term, and long-term financial goals. Understanding cash compensation (and whether or not people are hitting OTE) and equity compensation (vesting schedule, refreshes, etc.) play a significant role in my decision-making.

Further in my career, the compensation weighting will likely decrease as I become increasingly financially independent.

Work/Life Balance

My employer must respect boundaries and allow me to prioritize my family, health, and general well-being as necessary.

Further in my career, the work/life balance weighting will likely increase as my kids grow older and I take on additional responsibilities in the community.

Fulfillment of Job

Fulfillment from work can come in a variety of ways:

- Enjoying the day-to-day
- Impacting self (learning/progressing)
- Impacting others (co-workers, customers)

The weighting for fulfillment will likely increase as my career progresses.

Final two (weighted at 5%)

Promotion Path Clarity

When I join a company, I'm thinking long-term. I like to understand what my trajectory could look like if I made a sizeable impact. Understanding promotion criteria, timelines, titles, compensation, and span of control are all important elements to understand for promotion path.

If I were earlier in my career, this would be weighted higher, as it's important to show trajectory in your career to open up better opportunities.

Office Culture

I'm an advocate for in-office work at least one-two days per week. When I'm in an office, I want the environment to be welcoming and supportive of collaboration.

This would be more heavily weighted if I were in the office more than a small percentage of the time.

Feel free to change the criteria and/or weighting for your purposes! Whatever it ends up looking like, I do strongly recommend having a documented way to assess career opportunities.

Effective Candidate Outreach

I receive a ton of notes from AEs wanting a job at MongDB. This section breaks down what they almost all look like and how you can improve your job-seeking outreach.
Here's an example of what I usually receive:

"I'm interested in speaking with you about the High Tech Account Executive positions MongoDB is hiring for.

I want to apply for the position but wanted to get your insight on the role before applying.

Are you available to talk tomorrow at 10:45am?"

This is what this outreach sounds like to me:

"I think I might want to work for your company. Can you teach me about it so I can decide?"

Instead of putting the "burden" on the hiring manager, try this approach when you are reaching out:

- Share what you've learned about the company

- Share what you've learned about the role

- Share why you think you would be a good fit for the role

- Have a "low effort" CTA

It might look like this:

“Hey Kyle,

Blown away at the market opportunity I’m seeing for MongoDB. Seems like the growth of AI is an accelerant for your go-to-market.

It also seems like Mongo puts a major emphasis on rep development. Combining a huge market opportunity with dedicated rep enablement is incredibly appealing!

I’d love to walk you through how I’ve led my team in pipeline generation and quota attainment the last two quarters to see if my skill set may be a good fit for your org.

What’s the best way to ensure my application is reviewed by a member of your team?”

Outreach like this will immediately separate you from 95%+ of your competition for roles.

Enterprise Sales vs Sales Leadership

At some point, every successful seller that wants to stay in sales will need to decide between staying an individual contributor or entering the leadership path.

There is not a right or wrong answer - both roles offer phenomenal opportunity.

To help you think about your options, I'll share my experience and criteria used for my decision.

I had no desire to pursue a leadership role early in my career. I was wrapping up a fantastic year as an AE, my friends were promoting to the enterprise sales team, and I was determined to join them.

Then, my manager and VP encouraged me to use long-term thinking to inform short-term decisions.

As I went through the leadership vs. enterprise decision-making process, I ended up focusing on two areas:

- How I wanted to spend my time
- What I wanted to be known for

Here's a simple breakdown of the two routes:

Enterprise Sales

Where I'd spend my time:

Mostly with customers, including significant travel to customer locations

Main skills I'd develop:

Become an expert in specific industries, personas, and sales process

The legacy I'd work to achieve:

Be known as the rep that closes the biggest, most valuable deals

Sales leadership

Where I'd spend my time:

Hiring, developing reps, and improving internal processes

Main skills I'd develop:

Recruiting, coaching, and change management

The legacy I'd work to achieve:

Be known as a leader that helps others achieve career success

After building this breakdown, I gravitated toward leadership. However, I still didn't want to be a Team Lead, which was the next step in my career if I selected leadership.

The Team Lead role at my company was brutal: I'd have to carry a personal quota of a mid-senior rep while managing a team – two full-time jobs for the compensation of one.

I'd work more and get paid less in this role than in an enterprise AE role. My strong short-term preference was taking the AE role, despite the above analysis of time, skills, and legacy.

The question that tilted the scales was, "What do I want to be doing in twenty years?"

I didn't want to be running demos, planning accounts, and chasing down deals.

I did want to lead large sales orgs and shape companies GTM direction. Knowing where I wanted to be long-term pushed me to do something I didn't want to do in the short-term.

Sometimes, thinking less about "what do I want to do in the next two years" and more about "what do I want to be doing in twenty years" can help us make better short-term decisions.

Wrap-up

I don't consider myself to be very wise, but I do have the benefit of experience. I'll conclude my Frameworks with seven points I wish I would have known years ago:

1) No such thing as a "must win" deal

I've lost sleep over dozens of deals that I no longer remember. Win or lose, life goes on.

2) Success is measured in years, not quarters

Zoom out and play the long game. Most top performers have a period of struggle in their careers - keep going.

3) Worry more about the buyer process than your sales process

I lost a lot of deals trying to force buyers through an evaluation process that ignored where they were at in their journey.

4) You'll get ghosted no matter how well you sell

You can reduce it but you can't eliminate it. Don't take it personally.

5) $50k-$100k isn't expensive.

It's probably less than the economic buyer pays for their yearly mortgage. It's not that much money for a business.

6) Comparison is the thief of productivity

The time you spend tracking someone else's success is time you aren't creating your own.

7) No one will care more about your career than you

No one is coming to save you. You have to take ownership of your progression.

Thank you for investing your time and money into this resource. There's a lot of "noise" in the sales advice space, and I'm grateful you trusted me.

To your success!